India may not have always been treated as a friend but was not regarded as a foe either.

The very same nations that evoked anxiety through their geopolitics were the ones that stepped forward after the 1962 conflict with China. Their contribution to infrastructure creation and agricultural self-sufficiency also cannot be underestimated. Our stance towards the Western bloc as a whole was influenced by the totality of these experiences and considerations.

Looking back, it is telling that for the first few decades, India's preferred partners in the Anglosphere were the UK and Canada. Indeed, much of its early international forays took place in tandem with them, the mediations on Korea and Vietnam being prominent examples. The US was, of course, an overwhelming presence, but one long regarded with suspicion due to our ideological proclivities as much as strategic calculations.

A measurement of the distance that India's foreign policy has travelled over 75 years is also in changed attitudes in this respect. The more we got beyond the romanticism of the early years and viewed the world through the lens of hard realities, the greater was the merit that was discovered in partners hitherto kept at a distance. This was accelerated when India started looking eastwards and developing an Indo-Pacific agenda. As a result, it is now the US and Australia that are assessed as having critical value, including at the Quad. If there is a pointer here, it is that the alignment of geopolitical outlook is so central to the development of ties. Indo-Pacific strategies now offer a contemporary pathway in that regard.

Challenges, however, are not with just individual nations. India's relationship with the West as a whole needs an objective evaluation. In many ways, this group is a natural partner because its members share the attributes of a pluralistic society, democratic polity and market economy. Yet, this very commonness can also create its own frictions. The continuing hegemonism visible in many quarters in the West leads to an excessive advocacy of their particular practices and convictions. Often, it is lost on them that others have different traditions, practices and yardsticks, and that the West itself would not necessarily come out well if they were evaluated objectively and publicly. Moreover, these attitudes do not stop at advocacy and extend to promoting an actionable agenda as well. That comes into conflict with post-colonial polities like India, which are reasserting their identities and standing their ground.